

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

ARKANSAS STATE UNIVERSITY

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: March 11-12, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

ARKANSAS STATE UNIVERSITY

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

Overall Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
MEETS	APPROACHING	MEETS

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	EXCEEDS	MEETS
Recommendations		
A-State's alternative route enrollment has expanded tremendously with the addition of new licensure areas, particularly enrollment in the Special Education K-12 licensure program, which is an Arkansas certification shortage area. Currently, program completion rates for alternative route candidates are meeting targeted levels. Looking ahead, A-State should carefully monitor completion rates of their alternate route candidates, ensuring their candidates are receiving sufficient support to complete the program. <i>(Focus Area: Criteria 1.3a)</i>		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (I.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	EPPs were not asked to submit formal plans to meet the state review framework targets or to show evidence of acting on their plans as part of the Spring 2024 review cycle. As a result, all EPPs in this cycle will receive a rating of MEETS.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	375%	EXCEEDS

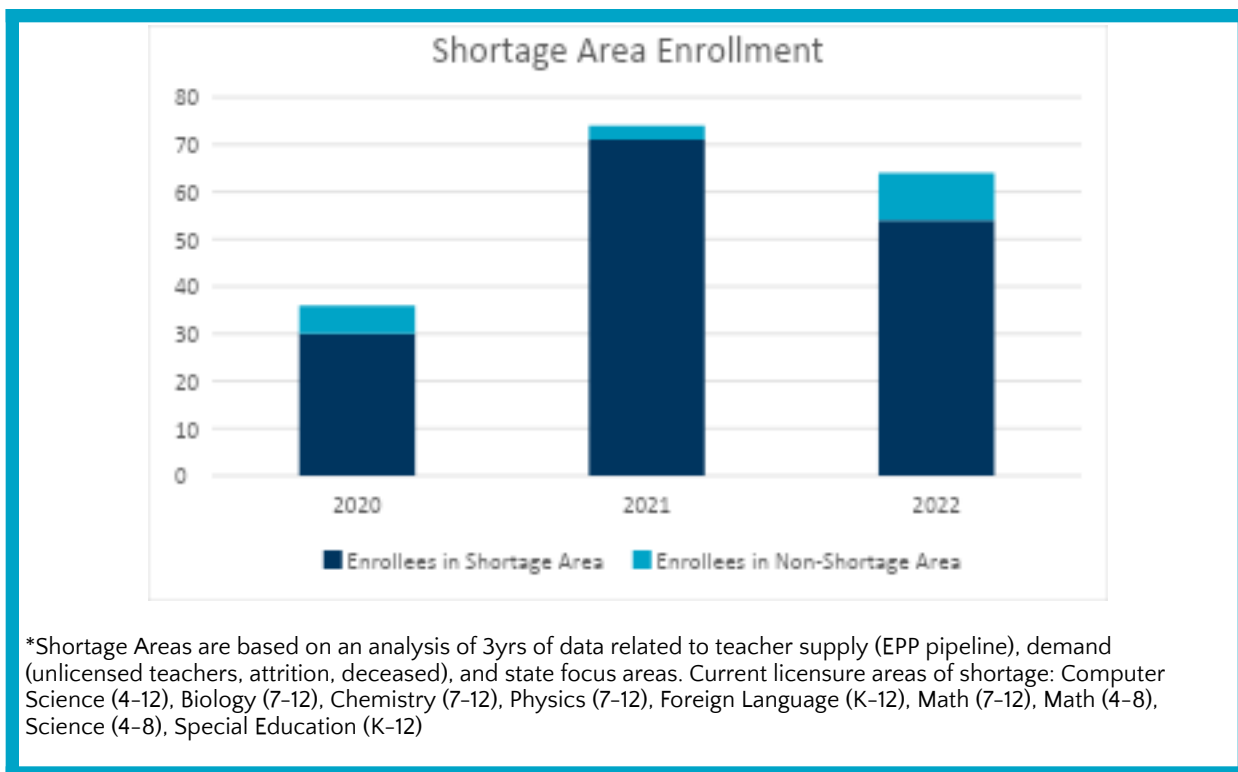
Enrollment

Metric is the percentage growth between the blue and green boxes

Year	Percentage Growth
2017	15%
2018	10%
2019	10%
2020	35%
2021	70%
2022	65%

*The enrollment growth target was established to close the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a “Meets” rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an “Exceeds” rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	89%	EXCEEDS



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	72%	MEETS



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	MEETS
Recommendations		
Teacher candidates in the alternative licensing program at A-State consistently earn high grades and evaluation ratings and have a track record for positively impacting student outcomes. The program provides online and in-person opportunities allowing students in the alternative route to earn their teaching license while working full-time, many of whom already work as the teacher of record in a classroom. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: • Document a clear and intentional process to fully support graduate students in their internship experience and identify experienced mentor teachers in their buildings who will support them. Build and maintain strong relationships with schools where teacher candidates work that may be outside the current list of partner districts. (Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2b Metric 2, 2.2c Metric 1) • Document consistent expectations for clinical supervisors and mentor teachers to provide high-quality feedback to teacher candidates built from coursework content and the clinical experience and links to student outcomes. (Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2b Metric 2 2.2c Metric 1) • Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates in the building are experienced, very effective, and, by the 2026-2027 school year, have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. (Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b) • A-State should continue planning to meet the state's one-year residency requirement, which will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond.		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
APPROACHING
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction
APPROACHING
The coursework in A-State's alternative program incorporates some nationally recognized best practices around content instruction. Reviewers noted that the course texts are on the approved "Arkansas Course Rating List" in both the Theories, Issues, and Methods in Reading (RDNG 6013) course and Advanced Readings and Interventions (RDNG 6943). HQIM and evaluation of approved materials are being introduced into the program next fall, though it is unclear if the expectation is to incorporate HQIM across all programs.

The state's Science of Reading requirement meets the awareness level throughout Art (K-12), Business Technology (4-12), and Mid-Level (4-8) licensure areas with approved programs (e.g. RDNG 6013, RDNG 6493, and RDNG 6013). The alternative route also includes Elementary Education (K-6) and Special Education (K-12), which are reviewed for proficiency by the Science of Reading Audit.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K-12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development
APPROACHING

Coursework somewhat familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. Some courses and syllabi indicate the state standard that will be taught, such as Curriculum Construction Elementary (ELED 6023) and Advanced Methods Teaching Middle Grades (MLED 6443). However, Advanced Teaching Methods for Mild/Moderate Disabilities (ELSE 6053) and Advanced Methods of Teaching Students with Significant Disabilities (ELSE 6073) do not mention how the course will align with standards. No evidence was provided to demonstrate how candidates will have the opportunity to vertically integrate standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area, and it is unclear how students in the alternative program who currently work as teachers of record have opportunities to experience various grade bands in their licensure area during their clinical internship semester.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
MEETS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses
MEETS

The Program of Study documents show that coursework is clearly and intentionally sequenced to build on previous coursework and shows progressive rigor for students in the alternative route for Special Education, Mid-Level, Elementary Education, Business Technology, and Art programs.

Throughout the coursework, there are clear retention checkpoints where candidates must show progress to maintain their spot in the program. The handbook also outlines a candidate intervention plan for those struggling to meet program requirements.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework
MEETS

Coursework incorporates Arkansas Teaching Standards in a way that develops candidates to meet the knowledge and skills of their licensure area. Almost all coursework incorporates and utilizes the teaching standards as evidenced in syllabi and the program handbook. For example, the Technology as a Tool for Teaching (TE 6243) syllabi references Arkansas Teaching Standards and includes tables that show alignment to TESS and course learning objectives. However, reviewers noted during an observation of course TE 6243, teaching candidates were asked to create six mini-lessons using the edTPA lesson plan. Reviewers did not cite evidence or utilization of the AR Standards in this course, but the use of edTPA is aligned with AR Standards and TESS.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience
MEETS

Coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned with the clinical experience, and candidates have opportunities to reflect on alignment with their clinical supervisors. In the Course Instructor focus group, one participant discussed course-embedded assessments throughout the course that are specifically designed to be practical and able to be used "tomorrow" in the classroom. Additionally, most internship syllabi include opportunities for reflection.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors
MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas K-12 Standards, content knowledge, and pedagogy. The faculty roster highlights degrees, professional development, TESS training, K-12 teaching experience, areas of expertise, and research. Faculty members are evaluated annually, and A-State provides documentation and samples of coursework feedback. According to the university's narrative, "the initial programs' instructors' evaluations for fall 2023 range from 3.44 – 5.00, with supporting student statements. The overall mean for the unit was 4.41." During the Course Instructor focus group, nearly all participants confirmed they are expected to attend and present at regional, state, and national conferences and workshops to continue their development.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

From the evidence provided, reviewers observed that most course instructors show evidence of strong facilitation of coursework and provide feedback and support to their students. Feedback samples from course instructors to teaching candidates were provided from various courses. In the TE 6243 course observation, reviewers noted the "instructor has developed a course intended to prepare candidates to utilize technology effectively for teaching and in the creation of lesson plans." As evidenced in the Course Evaluation data, most evaluations submitted show teaching candidates "slightly agree" or "strongly agree" that their instructor is knowledgeable and that they would recommend their professor to other students.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

The overall sequence of clinical experiences somewhat builds off previous experiences and includes opportunities for learning and development. The "Program of Study" documents outline the required courses teacher candidates must take leading up to their 15-week internship experience. Teacher candidates in the alternative program may serve as the teacher of record in a school building without classroom experience. While all teacher candidates are required to complete coursework to prepare them for their classroom experience if they are not already hired as a teacher of record, most teachers enter into the alternative program as a teacher of record. Therefore, there is no sequence building up to the clinical experience.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

While A-State has a varied list of partner schools that provide opportunities for teacher candidates to work with students of varied needs, exposure to multiple experiences is limited for teachers in the MAT program. Because some teachers already serve as the teacher of record, they may not have opportunities to experience various grade levels or classroom settings. Teacher candidates who are not the teacher of record only have one 15-week internship opportunity and likely will only experience one school setting and one classroom.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers

APPROACHING

Some experienced mentor teachers are equipped to develop and support a teacher candidate. In the Partnership focus group, participants said that administrators select experienced mentor teachers who have demonstrated evidence of modeling an exemplary teacher experience and are successful at supporting the professional growth of

novice teachers. All mentor teachers have earned an “effective” or “highly effective” evaluation rating and have evidence of having a positive impact on student learners. However, no evidence was provided to demonstrate effective coaching skills by mentor teachers, such as evaluation data, trackers, or observations.

Note: By 2026–2027, evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have received DESE-recognized coaching training must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

There is a set of criteria for experienced mentor teachers: They must have at least three years of teaching experience and an effective or highly effective TESS evaluation rating. Administrators also look for teachers who’ve demonstrated evidence of modeling and exemplary teaching experience and who are successful at supporting teachers’ professional growth. If an alternative teacher candidate currently works as the teacher of record, the university works with their employer school’s administration to identify a mentor teacher within the building who meets the criteria listed above.

Note: By 2026–2027, evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have a minimum 3 years teaching experience, hold a standard Arkansas educators license with a Lead or Master Professional Educator designation, and have evidence of an annual rating of effective or higher in DESE’s Educator Effectiveness System must be shown to meet this metric

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Most program clinical supervisors (university supervisors) have evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with positive impact. All clinical supervisors hold advanced degrees, have multiple years of teaching experience, and have completed recent professional development. Clinical (University) supervisors are evaluated every semester at the end of the internship, and the results are shared with the department chair, dean, and head of the unit. Evaluation results of clinical supervisors from teacher candidates were submitted. Teacher candidates in the alternative program rated the feedback and support that they received from their clinical supervisors a 4.8 out of 5. Survey results showed that teaching candidates felt the overall performance of their clinical supervisor was also 4.8 out of 5.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

APPROACHING

Candidates sometimes receive high-quality feedback. In one of the Coaching Session observations, reviewers noted that the teacher candidate made many errors in pronouncing sounds while teaching reading that were never corrected by the clinical supervisor. Also, they noted the clinical supervisor did not encourage reflection or learn more about the teacher candidate’s thoughts. In the Clinical Experience focus group, participants shared mixed experiences about the feedback they’ve received, some stating they receive consistent, daily feedback from their university supervisor. At the same time, another said, “My A-State supervisor isn’t critical about things that I work on. They are reluctant to be tough on us.”

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

APPROACHING

Collaborative processes are in place with most districts or schools to co-construct the clinical experience. The Educator Program Advisory Council (EPAC) meets twice yearly to create and review mutually agreeable procedures and policies for continuous improvement. In the School Partnership focus group, one principal said their partnership with A-State is over 25 years old and didn’t know what they would do without the school’s EPP program. All the other school partners agreed. However, there seems to be a disconnect between the collaboration with clinical

supervisors and mentor teachers and the support provided to teacher candidates. In the Clinical Experience focus group, all participants agreed that mentor teachers and clinical supervisors are not in communication and do not know their goals and what participants should be doing. One focus group participant said, "There is a problematic disconnect."

Teacher candidates in the alternative program may not work in a partner school/district but could work in schools across the state or country. No evidence was submitted to highlight how A-State works with schools outside their current partnerships or existing collaborations.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors
MEETS

Collaborative processes are in place to support and develop clinical supervisors. All supervisors are recommended to attend the Capstone Internship meetings, which include TESS professional development, coaching training, and edTPA seminars. All new supervisors are required to attend an orientation meeting. All supervisors have attended the co-teaching training and will have attended the Aspiring Teacher Rubric training sponsored by the DESE before implementation. During each EPP faculty meeting, the director provides resources and updates to supervisors to increase understanding of effective practices.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework
MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework
MEETS

Most candidates show proficiency in their coursework. As evidenced in the "Validations" documentation, most candidates meet the requirements for their coursework, and all candidates must earn 100% on their validation before entering their capstone semester. A-State has five checkpoints ranging from admission to graduation to support teacher candidates staying on track, as explained in the "Teacher Education Handbook." Alternative route teacher candidates must have an overall GPA of 3.0 and nothing lower than a "C" in their graduate coursework. Each checkpoint is reviewed by the candidate, their advisor, and the program office to maintain retention in the program.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework
MEETS

Candidates are provided with individualized support plans if their coursework is not on track. Candidates who are not showing growth are placed on an improvement plan. The "Teacher Handbook" says they are referred to the Program Department Chair and then the Educator Review Committee for intervention and remediation. The committee recommends interventions to help the candidate achieve the expected targets and benchmarks. During the Course Instructor focus group, instructors noted they provide individualized support by reviewing results at the various checkpoints and developing specific improvement plans for students when issues appear during the initial evaluation. Participants from the Course Instructor focus group also gave examples of additional faculty support, including email check-ins, discussion boards with reflective dialogue, and face-to-face Zoom meetings to touch base with students.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship
MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones
MEETS

A-State has a set of clear and appropriate goals and milestones for candidates' clinical internships, and most candidates meet these goals and milestones. In the Teacher Education Handbook, there are clear checkpoints in place for the clinical internship and "exit" or graduation checkpoints that outline expectations to be successful. In the Fall

2022 TESS summative evaluations, all students earned a 3.1 or above; in the Spring 2023 evaluation, all students earned a 3.5 or above.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

A-State provided evidence that candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. All teacher candidates must complete the edTPA portfolio, which requires candidates to complete lesson reflections, internalizations, and videos of their classrooms. Through these practices, teaching candidates analyze and reflect on student data. Program Directors cited using TESS and Danielson throughout their programming, which includes components focused on student growth. In Coaching Session observation debriefs, there was evidence that the coach and candidate discussed the importance of student work and exit tickets and how to analyze student data.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Most candidates receive a score of “effective” on the TESS evaluation. In the Fall 2022 TESS summative evaluations, all students earned a 3.1 or above; in the Spring 2023 evaluation, all students earned a 3.5 or above.

Note: By 2024–25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

APPROACHING

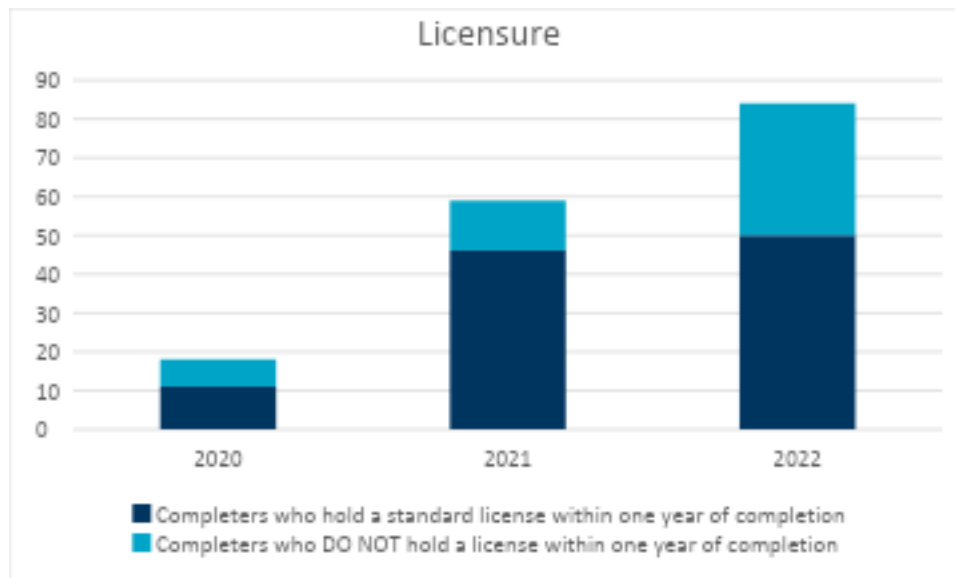
Most candidates with varied needs are provided with the support they need. However, there was no evidence submitted to demonstrate how high-performing teacher candidates receive opportunities and feedback that encourage retention. In the Program Director focus group, a participant noted that the administration identifies struggling teacher candidates and immediately implements support strategies. The teacher candidate will meet with the faculty, clinical supervisor, and mentor teacher to develop a plan and check progress toward getting back on track.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
MEETS	EXCEEDS	BELOW
Recommendations		
Ninety percent of A-State's alternative route enrollees who are employed are provisionally licensed. Three years after completion, completers become licensed, work in Arkansas public schools and districts (including priority districts and subjects) and stay in the classroom for multiple years. Recommendations include: - Establish programmatic support to ensure that alternative program enrollees are prepared to obtain standard licensure immediately following completion. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.1b)</i> - Analyze EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b)</i> - Ensure that program completers have the capacity to impact student growth and can demonstrate that capacity in the classroom. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3c)</i>		

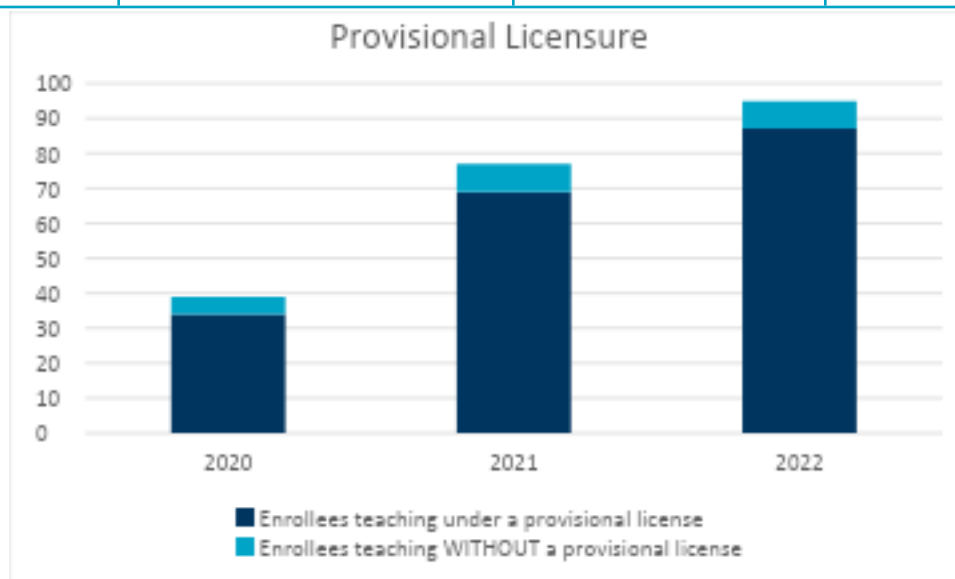
INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	76%	66%	APPROACHING



Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	69%	90%	EXCEEDS



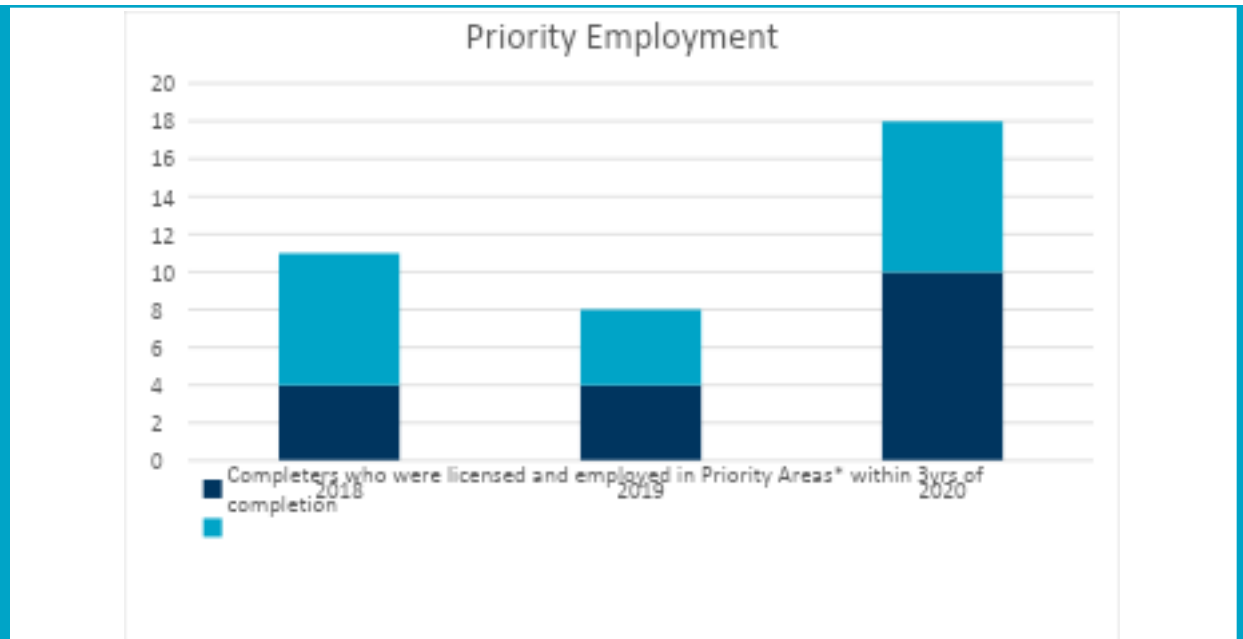
Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
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Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	n/a	n/a	n/a

INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	64%	73.0%	EXCEEDS												
Employment <table><caption>Employment Data (Approximate)</caption><thead><tr><th>Year</th><th>Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion</th><th>Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>2018</td><td>7</td><td>4</td></tr><tr><td>2019</td><td>5</td><td>3</td></tr><tr><td>2020</td><td>15</td><td>3</td></tr></tbody></table> ■ Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion ■ Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion				Year	Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	2018	7	4	2019	5	3	2020	15	3
Year	Completers who were licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion	Completers who WERE NOT licensed and employed within 3yrs of completion													
2018	7	4													
2019	5	3													
2020	15	3													
Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	40%	48.6%	EXCEEDS												



*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

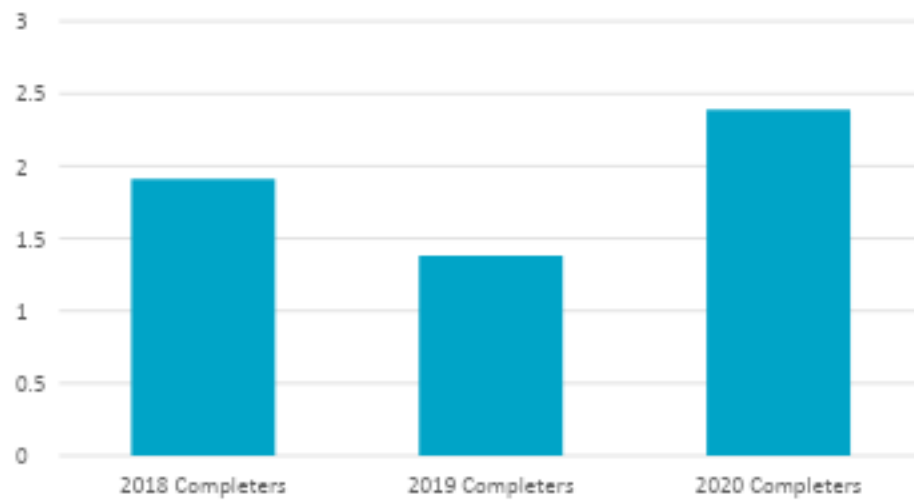
Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.7	2.03	EXCEEDS

Average experience three years after completion



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	81%	69.6%	BELOW
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	75%	76.1%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	15%	BELOW

